

Why do people say AI is bad for the environment for using power, when they're not the ones omitting CO2 into the atmosphere to make said power?

Posted by u/PatatoPhish • • 0 points • 13 comments

Why do people blame AI just for using a lot of power? Why not get mad at the power system that encourages all the emissions and discourages renewable energy? My feeling is that the people who say it's bad for the environment hear it on social media and repeat it without understanding because so many people hate AI now.

My schtick is that, AI is here and it's only going to grow whether we like it or not, so instead of fighting the AI companies, why don't people fight the corrupt system allowing the damage to the environment?

Comments

u/Successful-Head-736 • 1 points • 2025-07-01 00:37 UTC

The power grid is complex and not easily adaptable to sudden changes. It must constantly maintain a balance between electricity supply and demand in real time. This needs a baseload energy source which still come from fossil fuels. Data centers are increasing electricity use, and they add more stress to the grid and make maintaining that balance more difficult.

u/PatatoPhish • 1 points • 2025-07-01 01:24 UTC

surely there are measures in place to prevent total collapse due to data centers right? you seem to know more about this than me

u/Scatmandingo • 2 points • 2025-07-01 00:34 UTC

I think what you are missing is that the growth rate of consumption caused by AI is faster than the rate renewable solutions can be put in place to handle it. So the only option is to increase the usage of traditional fuels.

u/PatatoPhish • 1 points • 2025-07-01 00:46 UTC

That is something I hadn't considered. I think long term, renewable can catch up if/when we want/need it to.

u/hellshot8 • 3 points • 2025-07-01 00:27 UTC

this isnt really an argument that makes sense

>Why do people blame AI just for using a lot of power? Why not get mad at the power system that encourages all the emissions and discourages renewable energy?

these are the same things, no? these aren't mutually exclusive

u/PatatoPhish • -1 points • 2025-07-01 00:34 UTC

AI companies aren't power companies. They don't decide how the power they need to use gets made. You and I have both individually contributed some CO2 to the environment if you've used electricity, driven a gas car or flown in a plane.

It seems almost hypocritical to me to get mad at AI companies for the same thing

u/hellshot8 • 1 points • 2025-07-01 00:36 UTC

If I make a company that's whole thing is burning plastic, you should be mad at me for burning the plastic. You can also be mad at the people who provide me with the plastic, but its still definitely my fault that I made a company that just burns plastic

>You and I have both individually contributed some CO2 to the environment if you've used electricity, driven a gas car or flown in a plane.

the scale here is so profoundly different that im not sure you fully understand what you're talking about

u/PatatoPhish • -1 points • 2025-07-01 00:42 UTC

I understand well the amount of power AI consumes, and I also understand your point, but

1. Why does scale change anything about the hypocrisy? If I kill one person, am I still right to get mad at someone who's committed genocide? I think both are guilty.

2. Comparing AI to burning plastic is an unfair comparison. AI is already changing the course of human history for the better, with lots of applicable uses for everyone.

u/hellshot8 • 2 points • 2025-07-01 00:45 UTC

> Why does scale change anything about the hypocrisy? If I kill one person, am I still right to get mad at someone who's committed genocide? I think both are guilty.

I mean this is just a silly comparison. if I chop down one tree, its fine. If i chop down 10 million, that's serious damage to the environment. Let's be serious here, you have to understand this concept - I dont believe that you dont.

>Comparing AI to burning plastic is an unfair comparison.

AI in general? sure i guess. I'm not complaining about the AI being used to discover new ways to fold protiens or whatever. I think generative chatbots are a net negative and comparing it to complete waste is totally fine

u/PatatoPhish • 0 points • 2025-07-01 00:48 UTC

I think we've gotten to the bottom of this. You really think LLMs like chatGPT are a net negative for humanity?

u/hellshot8 • 2 points • 2025-07-01 00:50 UTC

I think their use is mostly tech-hype, yes.

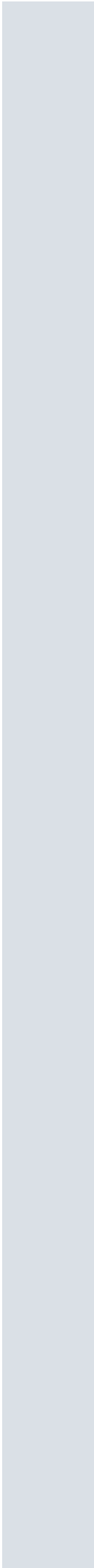
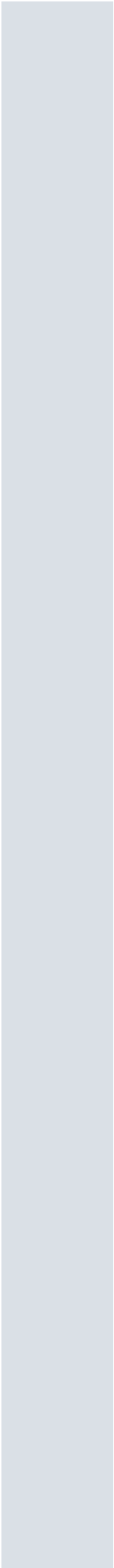
u/PatatoPhish
• 1 points •
2025-07-01
01:31 UTC

can i ask
why you
feel that
way?

as
someone
who
graduated
from high
school this
year,
believe me
when i say
ive seen the
harm that
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but, to me,
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